Always . . . Patsy Cline

By Ted Swindley

LOUISE - VOICE-OVER: Well, friends, let's not keep you waiting any longer tonight. Let's have a swell Grand Ole Opry welcome for our special guest star, Miss Patsy Cline *[Music cue]*

PATSY: Howdy everybody, and welcome to the Grand Ole Opry!

Honky Tonk Merry-Go-Round
I'M ON A HONKY TONK MERRY-GO-ROUND
MAKING EVERY SPOT IN TOWN
STARTING OUT EARLY, COMING HOME LATE
EVERY NIGHT WITH A BRAND NEW DATE

I'M ON A HONKY TONK MERRY-GO-ROUND
ACTIN' LIKE A FOOLISH CLOWN
STILL RACIN' THOSE BLUES THAT YOU LEFT WITH ME
WONDERIN' IF I'LL EVER BE FREE

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *On September 8, 1932 a very special little girl entered this world. Her given name was Virginia Patterson Hensley.*
ACTRESS 2: *Many years later, the world would come to know her as County Music sensation-PATSY CLINE.*
ACTRESS 1: *This selection "Always…Patsy Cline" is more than a tribute to the legendary country singer who died tragically at age 30 in a plane crash in 1963.*
ACTRESS 2: *It's based on a true story about Cline's friendship with a fan from Houston named Louise Seger, who befriended the star in a Texas honky-tonk in l961, and continued a correspondence with Cline until her death.*
ACTRESS 1: *The show's title was inspired by Cline's letters to Seger, which were consistently signed*
TOGETHER: *"ALWAYS… Patsy Cline" By Ted Swindley*

LOUISE: Now the first time I ever heard Patsy Cline sing it wasn't on the Grand Ole Opry. No, the first time I ever heard Patsy Cline sing she was in my livin' room. That was in January, 19 and 57. Well this particular momin', I was doin' the dishes, as usual, but subconsciously, I was listening to that television. When all of a sudden I heard this voice that absolutely stopped me in my tracks. I said, " My God, that sounds like I've always

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wanted to sing." So, I threw the spoons and forks in the kitchen sink and went tearing into the living room to see who it was.

I said, "Get outta my way kids." and I looked and there was this chunky little country girl leaning back and leadin' into a wonderful country song called "Walkin' After Midnight" and I'll tell you I have never heard a voice that impressed me so. *[Music cue – Louise acts like she's watching her on the TV]*

PATSY: I GO OUT WALKIN' AFTER MIDNIGHT
OUT IN THE MOONLIGHT JUST LIKE WE USED TO DO
I'M ALWAYS WALKIN' AFTER MIDNIGHT
SEARCHIN' FOR YOU

LOUISE: That TV audience went wild. Then [Arthur] Godfrey said, "Well, little lady, I hope that record sells like hotcakes." And then Patsy said,

PATSY: "I just hope it sells like records."

LOUISE: And it did! Well, she must have been on that show every morning for about two weeks, and every morning you would find me right in front of that TV, waiting. *[She does the "TV pose" as if she is watching the TV staring up mesmerized]* One day, Godfrey said "Now here's a little girl from Virginia that I think you're going to be hearing a lot from." Then she just dropped out of sight. But I never forgot that voice and I never forgot the feeling it gave me.

By 1961, I was divorced, Yahoo!, hallelujah! And I had taken a job as an electronics technician. Well, we can't all be hairdressers! Anyway, the man I worked for loved country music, and he used to keep the radio in the lab tuned to one of our leading country music stations. Anyway, one day, all of a sudden, I heard that voice again and it absolutely stopped me in my tracks. Well they didn't say who it was, so I called the radio station to find out and they said, "That was Patsy Cline singing "I Fall to Pieces." Well, I called Hal Harris, the local disc jockey, right while he was on the air and I said, "HEY *[Very Bossy],* you play that one again for me.", and he did. *[Music cue]*

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PATSY: I FALL TO PIECES EACH TIME! SEE YOU AGAIN
I FALL TO PIECES HOW CAN I BE JUST YOUR FRIEND

LOUISE: Patsy's music made me feel so alive every time I heard it. I nearly worried that poor man at the radio station half to death. I'd call him every afternoon four or five times a day and everyday he'd say, "Louise, I just played your song.", and I'd say, "Well, flip her over and play the other side and in an hour play my song again." Well, this went on for about two months. Well one day I called in my request, as usual, and he said, "Oh, incidentally, she's coming to town. She's going to be over at the Esquire Ballroom next Friday night."

So I told my bunch, I said, "We're gonna wear our western clothes and we're gonna get there at 6:30." My boyfriend said, "For Cryin' in a bucket, Louise, the band don't even start until 8:00." I said, *[emphatically]* "I DON'T CARE, WE'RE GONNA BE THERE AT 6:30." Sometimes you just have to talk to them that way.

(During the rest of Louise's speech, Patsy continues to softly hum "I Fall to Pieces" as she does a check of the stage and instruments, check music, mics and lights, etc. Toward the end of the speech, Patsy leaves the stage and goes to a juke box in the corner of the bar)

When we went stompin' in out there, they were still cleaning the place. Except for the people at the bar we were the only ones there. Well I picked us out a table right in front of the bandstand. My boss said, *[note: Louise affects a voice for her boss as a high pitched nasal old man.]* "Damn, Louise, we won't even be able to hear ourselves talk." I said, "HEY!- we did not come here to hear ourselves talk. We come here to hear Miss Patsy Cline."

We'd been sittin' there about 15 minutes when I saw this girl come in across the way. She walked across the dance floor and sat down by the juke box. *[PATSY sits on the barstool]* She looked so lonesome sitting there. I was the only one watching her, nobody else was paying her any attention at all.

PATSY: ***It Wasn't God Who Made Honky Tonk Angels***
AS I SIT HERE TONIGHT THE JUKEBOX PLAYING
THOSE TUNES ABOUT THE WILD SIDE OF LIFE
AS I LISTEN TO THE WORDS THEY ARE SINGING

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IT BRINGS MEMORIES WHEN I WAS A TRUSTING WIFE

LOUISE: She took off her rain coat *[PATSY does so]* and laid it on the back of the chair. She had on a pale pink two-piece cotton suit. Well something in my mind went DING! DING! DING! Why, it was just like our minds were talking to one another, like she was saying, "Hello, I'm, Patsy Cline, who are you?" As I looked at her sitting there in that nearly empty ballroom, I wondered what that honky-tonk merry-go-round life of hers is really like. *[Louise watches Patsy intently] [Sings softly]* SHE'S ON A HONKY-TONK MERRY-GO-ROUND *[from opening song]* So I just picked myself up *[LOUISE hoists her bosom up and makes a beeline to PATSY, but then approaches her very timidly]* and I walked right on over to her, I said, "Excuse me, Miss Cline."

PATSY: *(looking at Louise and smiling)* Yes? *(Patsy extends her hand for a handshake, which Louise shakes rather exuberantly)*

LOUISE: My name's Louise and I just want you to know how fond I am of your music. And I was wondering, if you don't mind and if you have the time, Would you just stop by our table and say hello? *(to audience)* Now y'all listen up, 'cause you aint gonna believe what she said next.

PATSY: Well, why don't I just come over there and sit with y'all?

LOUISE: *(screaming and almost fainting)* OH MY GOD, WE WOULD BE THRILLED! Patsy, come on over and sit down with us.

PATSY: Well, help me out with this song first. ***Come on In And Make Yourself at Home***

NOW COME ON IN AND SIT RIGHT DOWN

AND MAKE YOURSELF AT HOME

TOGETHER: COME ON IN AND SIT RIGHT DOWN

AND MAKE YOURSELVES AT HOME. *(Louise is clapping as they both dance a do-si-do -- As the song ends, Patsy exits.)*

LOUISE: Lord . . . take me now! Well, my friends nearly fell off of their chairs. Patsy come over and sit down and in now time at all we were talking to one another like we'd known each other all of lives, she was no stranger to us. After a while, Patsy asked me if I would do

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her a favor. She wanted to know if I would go up there and stand by the drummer and make sure he didn't rush her. YES MA'AM, I COULD SURELY DO THAT . . .

(Louise takes her place on the stage and instructs the drummer as to the correct rhythm. Louise gets into the music and her physical moves are big and bold. Lots of arm, hip and leg movements for comic effect)

PATSY: ***Your Cheatin' Heart***

YOUR CHEATING HEART WILL MAKE YOU WEEP
YOU'LL CRY AND CRY AND TRY TO SLEEP
BUT SLEEP WON'T COME THE WHOLE NIGHT THROUGH
YOUR CHEATING HEART WILL TELL ON YOU
(Louise holds the final cut-off for the ban before ending the song with a final big comic move.) (laughing) Good job, Louise!

LOUISE: *(nonchalantly in her new role as manager and music director)* Thanks, Patsy. You did good too.

PATSY: *(to audience and especially Louise)* Lord's a mercy. I ain't doing too bad for a girl who can't even read notes and don't even know what key she sings in. I feel like I've come a long way from working in a drug store during the day to help support my momma and then singing in clubs at night in Winchester Virginia. Next month I go up to Las Vegas. I'll be doing four shows a day seven days a week. And I'll tell ya, this cat's ass will be draggin' the bottom out of that desert *(Both Patsy and Louise share a laugh)* Oh, it's a great life. I don't want to get rich. I just want to live good. Right, Louise?

LOUISE: You betcha! *(to audience)* Well, Patsy brought the House down. That place was filled with people just screaming and yelling. People were stomping and hollering for more. She signed autographs and a lot of her fans took pictures.

PATSY: Louise, honey, I have got to go, I've got to catch a plant to Dallas tomorrow.

LOUISE: You're never going to get a taxi out here this time of night. We'll take you, but first we're going to my house for some bacon and eggs. *(to audience)* and I want you to know that lady come right in MY kitchen and stood right alongside me frying up the bacon and eggs, just as big as you please. It was just like finding the sister I never had. When we finished eating, me and Patsy just sat around MY kitchen table and poured out hearts out.

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We talked about children . . . and husband problems, broken hearts, loves lost, loves found. We sounded like two people writing country songs.

PATSY: Louise, I think the good Lord broke the mold when he made you.

LOUISE: Yeah, you're right about that! [Then] Patsy told me about her marriage. She said she and Charlie weren't getting along too well. She told me about the hell raising arguments they would have and I knew only too well how she must be feeling. *(Patsy sings the following song as an internal monologue about her troubled marriage)*

PATSY: ***Crazy***

CRAZY, I'M CRAZY FOR FEELING SO LONELY
I'M CRAZY, CRAZY FOR FEELING SO BLUE
I KNEW, YOU'D LOVE ME AS LONG AS YOU WANTED
AND THEN SOMEDAY
YOU'D LEAVE ME FOR SOMEBODY NEW

LOUISE: We traded stories until the wee hours of the morning. Then Patsy said . .

PATSY: Louise, honey, I truly have enjoyed it but I've really gotta go, I've gotta catch a plane to Dallas tomorrow. Thank you for everything Louise – I want your address cause I don't want us to lose touch.

LOUISE: Goodnight, Patsy *(Louise exits)*

PATSY: ***Just a Closer Walk*** *(Patsy prayerfully sings. She is a woman with many struggles and her life is not as easy as it may seem)*

JUST A CLOSER WALK WITH THEE
GRANT IT, JESUS, IS MY PLEA
DAILY WALKING CLOSE TO THEE
LET IT BE, DEAR LORD, LET IT BE
LET IT BE, DEAR LORD, LET IT BE *(Patsy exits)*

LOUISE: So we exchanged addresses, but you know how it is, you figure, yeah, well,that will be the end of that. I'll never hear from her again. [But] you know what? In less than two weeks, I received the first in a long series of letter and telephone calls from Miss Patsy Cline. I tell you something, that country gal was a winner. *(Louise takes out a letter and reads silently while Patsy does the voice over)*

PATSY: . . . I'm going home next Tuesday and while there, they are proclaiming a Patsy Cline Day in my hometown. Ain't that a kick in the head? The Mayor is gonna be there and

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recognize me and so one. Anyway, it sure is a good feeling. I can't really believe it. I still want all of you to come down and see us at the Opry. Hope to see you again soon.

TOGETHER: Love, Always . . . Patsy Cline.

LOUISE: One morning about two years later, I was driving to work and they come on the radio and said that Patsy Cline had been killed in an airplane crash on her way back to Nashville. She was thirty years old. It had only been six years since I first heard Patsy sing on the Arthur Godfrey show.

PATSY: *(off-stage)* I GO OUT WALKIN' AFTER MIDNIGHT
OUT IN THE MOONLIGHT JUST LIKE WE USED TO DO
I'M ALWAYS WALKIN' AFTER MIDNIGHT
SEARCHIN' FOR YOU

LOUISE: That's been a long time ago, but I still call that radio station and I still ask them to play Patsy Cline for me. And as I look at the letters that she wrote to me, I remember . . . and I know she meant it when she signed each and every one of them Love . . . Always . . Patsy Cline.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
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Original Script can be purchased at http://www.tedswindleyproductions.com/product/always-patsy-cline/

Source citations and Links to music and lyrics appear below for reference purposes:

- ***Honky Tonk Merry-Go-Round - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ro1IEnyvfVk***
  Frank Simon/Stan Gardner – Sony/ATV Acuff Rose Music
- ***Walkin' After Midnight - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xiKsAuv7O7c***
  Don Hecht/Alan Block – Sony/ATV Rose Music
- ***I Fall to Pieces - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iuZTk1hdpMs***
  Hank Cochran/Harlan Howard – Sony/ATV Tree Publishing
- ***It Wasn't God Who Made Honky Tonk Angels - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-XEnxou-_80***
  JD Miller - International Copyright Group, Inc.
- ***Come on In and Make Yourself at Home - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=u83ZtHuUXDM***
  VF "Pappy Stewart – Sony/ATV Acuff Rose Music
- ***Your Cheatin' Heart - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fKZRp515SmY***
  Hank Williams, Sr. – Sony / ATV Acuff Rose Music
- ***Crazy - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6QEDb3xzdec***
  Willie Nelson – Sony/ATV Tree Publishing
- ***Just a Closer Walk - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=I6fqI50v1Kk***
  (Traditional)

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